

Prior Authorization Policy Manual 2026

Effective January 1, 2026 | Confidential · For Internal Use

1. Overview

This policy manual establishes prior authorization requirements for all procedures, services, and medications covered under commercial and Medicare Advantage plans effective January 1, 2026. Prior authorization is required before certain services are rendered to ensure medical necessity and coverage eligibility.

2. Imaging Services · MRI

All MRI procedures (CPT codes 70553, 71552, 72148, 72141, 72156) require prior authorization for commercial plan members. Authorization must be obtained through the designated provider portal at least 72 hours prior to the scheduled service date. Emergency MRI requests may be submitted within 24 hours post-service with supporting clinical documentation. Failure to obtain prior authorization may result in claim denial.

3. CT Scans and Advanced Imaging

CT scans of the abdomen, pelvis, chest, and head (CPT codes 74177, 74178, 71250, 70450) require prior authorization for commercial plans when ordered as non-emergency outpatient procedures. Inpatient CT scans are covered under the global inpatient authorization. Documentation required includes physician order, diagnosis code, and clinical notes supporting medical necessity.

4. Mental Health and Behavioral Services

Outpatient mental health services require prior authorization beginning with the 13th visit in a calendar year. Inpatient psychiatric admissions require notification within 24 hours of admission. Substance use disorder treatment including residential rehabilitation requires pre-authorization. CPT codes 90832, 90834, 90837 are subject to these limits.

5. Specialty Medications and Biologics

Specialty biologic medications administered in office (J-codes) require prior authorization for all plan types. Step therapy is required: members must demonstrate clinical failure of at least two preferred alternatives before biologic approval. Documentation must include treatment history, prior therapy failures, and physician attestation. Effective January 1, 2026 for all commercial and Medicare Advantage members.

6. Surgical Procedures

Elective surgical procedures with CPT codes in the 10000-69999 range require prior authorization. Medically necessary procedures require supporting documentation including operative notes, diagnostic results, and physician certification.

Emergency surgeries are exempt but require retrospective notification within 48 hours.

7. Durable Medical Equipment

Durable medical equipment (DME) including CPAP machines (CPT E0601), wheelchairs (E1130-E1220), and hospital beds (E0250) require prior authorization for rental or purchase exceeding \$500. Documentation required: physician order, certificate of medical necessity, and diagnosis codes.

8. Authorization Process

Providers must submit requests via the online portal or fax to the utilization management department. Standard review: decision within 3 business days. Urgent review: decision within 72 hours. Emergency situations: retrospective review within 30 days. Denial appeals must be submitted within 60 days of denial notification.